

No.1* Birla Institute of Technology and Science (BITS) Pilani *Pilani*

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ENGINEERING THE NEXT CONVERGENCE

BITS Pilani maintains its top spot in private engineering education and is moving to an interdisciplinary approach that combines AI, health tech, sustainability and more

By **SONAL KHETARPAL**

Reminiscing about his time as a student at BITS Pilani from 1980 to 1984, Bengaluru-based Harish Bhat, former brand custodian of the Tata Group and author of five national bestsellers, said, "I entered BITS Pilani as a starry-eyed boy and left as a confident adult." After a protected life with his parents in Madurai and Kollam, the experience BITS Pilani offered was a "crucible of life". The college, he says, was about more than getting an engineering degree. It opened up the world of liberal education, which few technology institutions offered then, allowing Bhat to venture into Philosophy, Psychology and Literature, and take responsibility for his own timetable.

BITS Pilani has long focused on a holistic education. Yet again, 40 years later, the school is revamping itself for a 'BANI' world, a term coined by American futurist Jamais Cascio—one that is Brittle, Anxious, Nonlinear and often Incomprehensible.

Job roles are changing fast and new ones are emerging. So, BITS Pilani is not preparing students for a fixed set of jobs but the long innings. Says V. Ramgopal Rao, Vice-Chancellor, Birla Institute of Technology & Science (Pilani, Hyderabad, Goa, Dubai and Mumbai), "We are moving to a model where students learn strong fundamentals and the ability to connect disciplines."

AI, data, semiconductors, sustainability, health technologies and digital systems are no longer separate worlds; students should be able to move between them. New undergraduate programmes in AI, Mathematics and so on are more contemporary, interdisciplinary and connected to real life. "These degrees reflect where India needs capacity," says Rao.

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"Our internship model, student startups, undergraduate research, flexible academic structure and strong industry engagement have made BITS distinctive for decades"



PROFESSOR V. RAMGOPAL RAO
Vice chancellor, Birla Institute of Technology & Science (Pilani, Hyderabad, Goa, Dubai and Mumbai)